

Defining Chymistry Through Insults? Michael Maier's Accusations of Alchemical Fraud in the Entrepreneurial Marketplace

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1 Abstract

EN This article investigates Michael Maier's (1569–1622) strategic use of invectives in his self-fashioning as an expert in the marketplace of entrepreneurial alchemy. Maier's insults not only represent performances of expertise but also defend *aurum potabile* as a medical strategy. Building upon the adage that “the best defense is a good offense,” this study explores how chymists utilized the pervasive notion of alchemical fraud to their advantage. To that end, it examines Maier's works *Coelidonia* (1609), *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616), *Jocus Severus* (1617), and *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) as well as his English friend Francis Anthony's *Apologia* (1616), to which he contributed material.

DE Dieser Beitrag untersucht Michael Maiers (1569–1622) Verwendung von Invektiven als performative Strategie zur Selbstinszenierung auf dem alchemischen Markt. Seine Beschimpfungen dienen nicht nur dazu, die eigene alchemische Expertise zur Schau zu stellen, sondern auch, die Anwendung von Trinkgold als medizinische Strategie zu verteidigen. In Anlehnung an das Sprichwort “Angriff ist die beste Verteidigung” zeigt dieser Artikel wie Chymiker die weit verbreitete Vorstellung von alchemischem Betrug zu ihrem Vorteil nutzten. Betrachtet werden dazu Maiers Werke *Coelidonia* (1609), *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616), *Jocus Severus* (1617), und *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) sowie die *Apologia* (1616) seines englischen Freunds Francis Anthony, zu der er Material beisteuerte.

2 Introduction

Michael Maier (1569–1622), a prominent German iatrochemist, is celebrated for his alchemical emblem book *Atalanta fugiens* (1617/18) and more than twenty Neo-Latin alchemical tracts published during the 1610s.¹ Beyond his prolific writing, Maier was an active practitioner of chymistry, engaging hands-on in the art he so eloquently described. This essay examines Maier's strategic use of invectives and apologetic tactics to defend his livelihood against his critics. His personal attacks and

¹ For a biographical overview see Leibenguth 2002 and Tilton 2003.

defenses testify to the wider disputes and allegations of fraud within alchemy while offering a glimpse into Maier, the practitioner, through the lens of his literary output.

Personal feuds are fought between the lines in many of Maier's printed works, highlighting the challenges he faced throughout his career. Notable incidents include a brawl with a fellow student during his medical studies in Padua, resulting in his abrupt departure, but also his own experiences being defrauded by a fellow alchemist, defending an English friend against fraud accusations, and being banned from the entrepreneurial marketplace in Frankfurt, which compelled Maier to focus on writing and publishing instead of practicing medicine.

Maier's oeuvre not only elucidates his conception of chymistry but, more importantly, reveals how he and his contemporaries leveraged the widespread notion of alchemical fraud to their advantage within the competitive marketplace of entrepreneurial alchemy. The rise of entrepreneurial alchemy in the 16th century, especially in princely courts, was tied to economic pursuits such as mining and technological advances. Patrons fueled the market for entrepreneurial alchemy as a practical technology through their increased demand. Chymists now had to meet the standards of existing industries, leading to a new conception of alchemical fraud, which originally denoted a simple breach of contract rather than moralized deceit in the Holy Roman Empire. Nevertheless, a fraudulent alchemist persona, tainted with immorality, was popularized through Humanist critiques of early modern commerce. In more practical contexts of patronage, chymistry was seen as a potential solution to the economic challenges of the time. Thus, both practitioners and their patrons had a vested interest in attributing alchemical failure to individual practitioners' deceit or incompetence.² Maier, while undoubtedly erudite and a scholar, also practiced alchemy in an entrepreneurial way, that is to sustain himself and, quite successfully, as a means to achieve upward social mobility.³

² On alchemical fraud, see Nummedal 2004, 2007 and Zuber 2021. Nummedal 2007 explores the debates surrounding authentic and fraudulent alchemy, along with broader issues of authority and knowledge in early modern Europe. She reveals how entrepreneurial alchemy, involving more than just the self-fashioning and dissimulation common in courtly life, played a vital role in the economy through trading books, secrets, techniques, and labor. Entrepreneurial alchemists, akin to Italian 'professors of secrets,' capitalized on the expanding print market and their unique position between academia and the workshop to profitably share artisanal and natural secrets. Investigating the prevalent notion of alchemical fraud, she shows how early modern discussions about alchemy's nature and limits intersected with the societal and cultural figure of the alchemist (Nummedal 2007, 5–6; chapter 2 *The Alchemist's Personae*, 40–72; 174–177). Zuber 2021 analyzes how the widespread narrative of alchemical fraud affected Peter Moritz's work with Robert Boyle (1627–1691) and Ambrose Godfrey (1660–1741). He argues that this alchemical stock tale not only dominated Godfrey's account but actively influenced the events revolving around financial liability and intellectual property in the context of alchemical experiments. The pervasive suspicion of fraud led Boyle and other patrons to withhold their full support. This trapped the entrepreneurial alchemists employed by them in a cycle of failure and mistrust, diminishing their ability to fulfill their alchemical promises due to inadequate resources. Zuber demonstrates that this evolving fraud narrative, internalized rather than explicitly stated, significantly accelerated alchemy's decline in the early 18th century, as it became synonymous with deceit.

³ Nummedal's definition of 'entrepreneurial alchemy' denotes business-oriented practices that do not necessarily exclude scholarly engagement, even though there are many practitioners of entrepreneurial alchemy who did not engage in scholarly discourse. She writes: "Few alchemists were erudite, Latin-speaking scholars who were able to see their ideas into print, nor were they 'important' in the traditional sense of contributing new alchemical theories or practices. *We might think of these more workday practitioners as entrepreneurial alchemists, in the sense that they practiced alchemy not solely for their own*

This essay argues that Michael Maier's invectives, while appearing as simple personal attacks, serve broader purposes under various, yet similar, circumstances. Initially, we note Maier's ambivalent stance towards Paracelsus, whom he alternately praises or criticizes to suit his immediate needs. Then, we observe how he crafted his alchemical 'coming of age' narrative, set against his first adversary, Johann Grasse (1560–1618), a Stralsund alchemist who exploited the still inexperienced Maier early in his career.⁴

The defense of potable gold spins through Maier's life like Ariadne's thread. During his stay in England, Maier came to the defense of his associate, Francis Anthony (1550–1623), who was in legal trouble due to his controversial potable gold treatments. After returning to the continent, Maier faced his own set of challenges in Frankfurt while attempting to market Anthony's *aurum potabile*. Now he, too, was confronted with accusations of fraud, which he ardently refuted through his anacreontic poem in *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616). This most vehement invective satirically suggests a lethal dose of hellebore to purge his opponent's madness, an insult just as hyperbolic as it is comical. Promoting *aurum potabile* as a medicine was at the core of Maier's business model and sales proposal. Accordingly, its defense was at the heart of his invectives.

Additionally, Maier often employed playful insults in his animal court poems, as exemplified in *Jocus Severus* (1617), where he defends Rosicrucianism from a flock of cantankerous birds. An analysis of *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) reveals Maier's efforts to defend chymistry as a discipline against allegations of fraud. In this vein, Maier frequently used the notion of false alchemy as a counterpoint to delineate his vision of an ideal chymist, a portrayal closely resembling himself.

This article investigates the use of insults and fraud accusations in Michael Maier's writings as a method of self-fashioning his expertise in entrepreneurial alchemy. Through surveying several of Maier's works across his literary career, it provides a panoramic view of his oeuvre. Examining Michael Maier's use of invectives offers not just a fresh perspective on the stock tale of alchemical fraud but also prompts a reevaluation of what defines an entrepreneurial alchemist and how accusations of alchemical fraud are intertwined with this identity. It illuminates the dynamics of who accuses whom of alchemical fraud, revealing that it is not simply a matter of scholars pointing fingers at non-scholarly entrepreneurs. Instead, the accusations of fraud found in Maier's writings are predominantly among scholar-entrepreneurs themselves, challenging each other's legitimacy and expertise.

edification, but also for the social and material benefits it offered. Nevertheless, if the majority of alchemists lacked the scholarly distinction of someone like Isaac Newton, their practices were an important part of the engagement with alchemy in the Holy Roman Empire.” (Nummedal 2007, 10. Emphasis added.) In general, see Nummedal 2007, chapter 2 *The Alchemist's Personae*, 40–72 and chapter 3 *Entrepreneurial Alchemy*, 73–95; as well as 11–13, 177.

⁴ Though Maier refrains from explicitly naming Grasse, his allusions are sufficiently clear to connect back to him, cf. Leibenguth 2002, 39.

3 Reasons to complain: Maier's life and work

To comprehend Michael Maier's scientific and professional disputes, it is necessary to briefly review his life.⁵ Born to a gold embroiderer, Maier exhibited academic promise early in his youth.⁶ Maier's career began with a Classical education and an extensive *peregrinatio Academica* that took him throughout Europe. He earned the title *poeta laureatus* in Padua but was forced to flee after a violent altercation with a fellow student. In 1596, Maier obtained his doctorate in medicine from Basel and began his alchemical experiments in Königsberg in 1599 while working as a physician. His first significant alchemical work, *De Medicina Regia* or *Coelidonia*, was submitted in 1609 when he sought a position at the court of Rudolf II in Prague, where he was later ennobled as Court Palatine.⁷ During or possibly before his time in Prague, he wrote numerous alchemical tracts, published in quick succession beginning in 1614. Following Rudolf II's death, Maier sought a new patron, first encountering Moritz of Hessen-Kassel in 1611. In 1612, he traveled to England, where he published the mythoalchemical *Arcana Arcanissima* (1613/1614).⁸ During his stay in England, he befriended English chymist Francis Anthony (1550–1623), assisting with the Latin translation of Anthony's *Apologie* (1616).⁹ In the summer of 1616, Maier returned to the continent. Stranded in Frankfurt due to illness and barred from practicing medicine or selling Anthony's potable gold, as he had intended, Maier hurriedly wrote 'tractatus itaque 6 vel 7 calente calamo' to sustain himself with the small payment he received for them.¹⁰ It is presumed he had already prepared several of these publications during his Prague stay. He became a physician to Moritz of Hessen-Kassel in 1618, but his 1618 tract *Viatorium* was already

⁵ A biographical overview can be gathered from: Leibenguth 2002; Tilton 2003.

⁶ The *Coelidonia* contains an autobiographical account which is our main source regarding Maier's earlier life: Maier 1609.

⁷ Maier 1609.

⁸ Maier 1614.

⁹ Lenke, Roudet, and Tilton 2014, 4–9.

¹⁰ "Atque sic aeger plaerumque haerens lecto nonnulla commentatus sum, ad Chymiam spectantia (quorum quaedam proelo subjecta sunt, quaedam subiicienda ab aliis reservantis ad próximas nundinas) lucello, quod inde evenit, magis incitatus, quam maturitate et emendatione ipsorum opusculorum: Tractatus itaque chymicos 6 vel 7 calente calamo deproperavi, sperans me hac via, tantum lucraturum, quo in locum praefixum commode transmearem" (Frankfurt am Main, Stadt- und Universitätsbibliothek, MS Ff. J. H. Beyer A. 161, p. 207 verso). - "And so, confined to bed due to illness, I have commented various writings on alchemy (some of which have been published, some are held back by others for publication at the next [Frankfurt book] fair), motivated more by the small profit that came from it, rather than the maturity and final edition of these works, I hastily wrote down 6 or 7 chemical treatises with a hot quill, hoping that I would gain enough money by this means, that I could comfortably travel to the predetermined place." Among those were, as Tilton suggests, *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616), *Lusus Serius* (1616), *Jocus Severus* (1617), *Atalanta fugiens* (1617), *Examen Furorum-Pseudo Chymicorum* (1617), *Silentium Post Clamores* (1617) and *Symbola Aureae Mensae* (1617), see Tilton 2003, 131. Although some of those had likely already existed in draft form, as a title list on the back of a 1611 letter to Moritz of Hessen-Kassel suggests, assuming the letter is dated correctly and the list was not added later, cf. footnote 199 Leibenguth 2002, 47. The list mentions 'De Theosophia Aegyptiorum' (an early draft of *Arcana Arcanissima*), 'De natura auri' (possibly *De Circulo Physico-Quadrato*) and 'Hermetis Melica; opus musicum cum germanicis et latinis textibus chemicis; tam intellectui quam sensibus accomodatimi 4. et 3. vocibus absolutum' (probably *Atalanta fugiens*); Gesamthochschul-Bibliothek, Kassel, 2° Ms. chem. 11 1, f.64^v. Maier 1616a, 1616b, 1617a, 1617b, 1617c, 1617d.

dedicated to a prospective patron.¹¹ Unfortunately, he struggled to find permanent employment until he died in 1622.

4 Non ille Bombastus! Maier and Paracelsus

Investigating Maier's stance on Paracelsus, a controversial figure, provides a baseline to interpret Maier's scholarly approach to conflict. Historically, Maier was often labeled a Paracelsian in research literature, a view challenged in the 1990s by scholars like Stiehle.¹² Yet there is, in fact, little evidence that Maier was a supporter of Paracelsus' overall philosophy, as he seldom mentions Paracelsus in his works and often praises figures critical of Paracelsus. Previous research has delineated several viewpoints on Maier's stance towards Paracelsus.¹³ Leibenguth discusses Maier's critical view of Paracelsus but acknowledges Maier's indirect respect for him, rooted in their common reliance on medieval alchemical traditions and regard for medical principles aligning with the Rosicrucian manifestos; he ultimately posits that Maier's critical approach towards Paracelsus should be understood as conciliatory, targeting not Paracelsus himself but his followers for misinterpreting his teachings.¹⁴ In contrast, Wels contests the portrayal of Maier as a Paracelsian, noting that Maier reconciled book learning with empirical knowledge, diverging from typical Paracelsian views that foreground the book of Nature as the main source of chymical knowledge.¹⁵

Maier's ambivalence towards Paracelsus likely stems from a strategic avoidance of confrontation that could hinder his professional interests. For instance, in a letter to a prospective patron, Gebhardt Johann von Alvensleben (1576–1631), Maier appears more receptive to Paracelsianism and magic than in his published works, suggesting a certain opportunistic adaptability in pursuit of financial gain.¹⁶ Maier's primary motivation for invectives and criticisms, thus, seems rooted more in entrepreneurial ambitions than scientific disagreements. Maier's approach to individuals in his field is characterized by opportunism, portraying them in a light most advantageous to his objectives at any given time. This is indeed the stance we will encounter in all situations of conflict discussed in this article. The subsequent examination of examples from Maier's published works will illustrate how his invectives often transcend mere personal attacks, serving broader communicative and strategic purposes.

¹¹ Maier 1618b; Maier's employment went on no longer than the end of 1620 at the latest as no mention is made of this employment, which was an important source of income and authority for Maier, in his 1621 *Civitas Corporis*: Maier 1621; Tilton 2003, 192.

¹² Stiehle 1991.

¹³ On Maier's relationship to Paracelsus and Paracelsianism: Stiehle 1991, 9–10, 247–60; Leibenguth 2002, 70–73; Tilton 2003, 60–61; Wels 2010, 160–63; Kühlmann and Telle 2013, 956–57; Lang 2021a, 71–76; Lang 2023, 114–116.

¹⁴ Leibenguth 2002, 70–73.

¹⁵ Wels 2010, 160–63.

¹⁶ Lenke, Roudet, and Tilton 2014.

5 *Coelidonia* (1609) and Maier's first opponent

Maier's inaugural alchemical publication, *Coelidonia* or *De Medicina Regia* (1609), published in Prague, marks the beginning of his career as an alchemical writer.¹⁷ The date and place of publication are enciphered on the back of the title page.¹⁸ The book is composed of three parts: an autobiographical account of Maier's life up to this point, filled with alchemical tropes¹⁹, a section on Maier's "god-given medicine" (*Coelidonia*) or *medicina regia* & verè *Heroica*, and a section detailing experiments from Maier's practice as a physician. Maier's reference to "golden medicine" throughout the book likely alludes to his interest in potable gold, sparked by an English yellow powder's miraculous effects on a patient.²⁰

Book 1 of *Coelidonia* introduces an unnamed antagonist against whom Maier constructs his alchemical hero's journey. This setting is in Danzig, where Maier, residing with a host specializing in the docimasy of metals, encounters alchemy amidst a community of enthusiasts. His early exposure to alchemical theory is through the extensive library of his host during the months the plague ravages the region.

He first experiences alchemical experiments with the aforementioned unnamed chymist, whom he would stilize as his archenemy in *Coelidonia*. The majority of the first autobiographical book of *Coelidonia* is devoted to Maier's bitter polemic against this individual, who Leibenguth identified as none other than Johann Grasse (1560–1618), a Stralsund jurist and alchemist, who would author *Arcani artificiosissimi aperta arca* in 1617 (Bringer: Frankfurt).²¹ Multiple indirect allusions and references attack Grasse throughout *Coelidonia* without ever explicitly stating his name.²² Grasse's deception, as Maier later admits, consisted only in charging an exorbitant price for misleading information. However, it is staged dramatically within Maier's autobiographical narrative (Lib. I). Maier's intention in *Coelidonia* is to illustrate his arduous ascent to the heights of alchemical theory and practice (Lib. II), culminating in him producing a panacea-like substance, whose effectiveness is demonstrated by numerous case studies in Lib. III. His nemesis is staged as a contrasting foil and retardation element for Maier's ascent to the ultimate alchemical achievement.²³

¹⁷ Maier 1609; Karpenko 2018; Lang 2021a, 180–82.

¹⁸ Purš and Hausenblasová 2005, 338.

¹⁹ Figala and Neumann 1994, 136; Leibenguth 2002, 3, 67.

²⁰ Leibenguth 2002, 38.

²¹ Grasse is referred to by the names of 'Grasse,' 'Grasshoff,' 'Crassaeus,' 'Grass(a)eus' and sometimes 'Chortolasaeus,' although the attribution of this last name to Grasse is uncertain: Telle 2009.

²² Maier 1609, 17–18, 23–24.

²³ Leibenguth 2002, 39.

Maier visited Grasse one winter after the latter had repeatedly assured him of his alchemical expertise – Maier seems to have believed this without reservation.²⁴ Yet Maier claims to have already harbored suspicions about the one named after grass (*a gramine dictum*) being a fraud but maintained contact in the hope that Grasse could assist him in procuring the true Mercury he sought.²⁵ He eventually labels him *grassator* (bandit), a trenchant pun on Grasse’s name.²⁶ After learning that Maier was gaining money from his wealthy patient, Grasse manipulated Maier, who was inexperienced in the harsh business of entrepreneurial alchemy, by supplying him with a steady flow of riddles, charging liberally for his services. This manipulation culminates in Grasse obtaining a significant payment of 400 Thaler from Maier, funds Maier had received from a wealthy patient. Maier’s metaphorical comparison of Grasse to a donkey in lion’s skin in reference to the Aesopian fable highlights Grasse’s pretense of wisdom and authority and suggests that Grasse’s intellectual inferiority will result in public embarrassment eventually.²⁷ The analogy underscores Maier’s sense of betrayal.

Despite challenges posed by the plague, Maier returned to Holstein in the winter of 1601/02, making stops at the residences of familiar alchemists en route. Arriving in Kiel in 1602, he procured materials for his experiments and, still hopeful, ventured to Stralsund to meet Grasse for a third time. During this final visit, Maier realized that Grasse had merely strung him along, offering nothing but misleading information in return for the hard-earned money from Maier’s Danzig host. Maier subsequently decided to place his trust in the writings of established alchemical authorities, notably Basilus Valentinus, whose works he would go on to translate into Latin in *Tripus Aureus*.²⁸ Maier’s journey illustrates a costly learning experience at the hands of a fraudster who demanded large payments for dubious information, a beginner’s mistake. Nevertheless, aside from the financial loss, it seems that Maier emerged from the ordeal without significant lasting damage.

²⁴ Lib. 1, Biiij^v: “[...] mediâ hieme redij ad eum, de quo mihi omnino persuasum erat, eum verâ Lapidis cognitionem habere (quod et ipse scripto et verbis mihi, ejusque uxor, aliquoties confessi fuerant) ab eo consilium auxiliumque expetens.” Maier 1609. “[...] in the middle of winter, I returned to him, of whom I was fully persuaded, that he had the true knowledge of the Stone (which both he himself and his wife had confessed to me in writing and in words on several occasions), seeking advice and help from him.”

²⁵ Lib. 1, Bⁱ: “Iam dictum à Gramine, ut falsarium, non verum habuisse mercurium cogitavi meque solùm jam habere vel mox habiturum speravi.” Maier 1609. “I already thought that the one called after grass did not have the true Mercury, like a deceiver, and hoped that only I already had it or would have it soon.”

²⁶ Lib. 1, Biiij^vf.: “Verum quibus insidijs, quo dolo, unus eorum, tanquam grassator, me circumvenit, alibi dictum est.” Maier 1609. “But how one of them, like a bandit, tricked me with what tricks and fraud, has been said elsewhere.”

²⁷ Lib. 1, Biiij^vf.: “Ne verò hic acquiescerem omninò, sed suam operam denuò implorarem, scriptis literis omnia mea iterum conturbat; exploratum nempe habens, me ab uno aegro divite mediocre summam accepisse. [...] Inde accidit, ut asinus aures suas sub leoninâ hactenus tectas ostenderit, dum tantus, tamque dives vir à me mutuo petit quadringentos taleros.” Maier 1609. “But so that I would not rest here at all, but would again implore his services, he disturbs all my affairs again in writing; he had indeed found out, that I had received a modest sum from one sick rich man. [...] Hence it happened that the ass showed its ears so far covered with a lion’s skin, when such a great and rich man asked me for a loan of four hundred talers.”

²⁸ Maier 1618a.

Despite these negative experiences, Maier's later writings show a more neutral stance towards Grasse, whose expertise he eventually seems to respect.²⁹ This shift may reflect Maier's reconsideration or strategic positioning, given Grasse's subsequent publication of an influential alchemical treatise *Arcani Artificiosissimi Aperta Arca. Das ist: Der allergrösten vnd künstlichsten Geheimnüssen der Natur eröffneten vnd offstehender Kasten* in Frankfurt in 1617. Maier continues to reference Grasse in his later works, such as *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum*, using familiar codenames like *grassator notissimus* (*Examen* 2, 21) and *à gramine denominatus* (*Examen* 4, 33).³⁰

6 Defending potable gold: Francis Anthony's *Apologia* (1616)

Michael Maier's move away from Königsberg and Danzig was possibly influenced by an encounter with a medicament that would captivate much of his professional life: *aurum potabile*, or potable gold. This interest was sparked when Maier's host received a yellow powder from a nobleman, which remarkably cured his ailment. This powder was likely the English “drinking gold” prepared by Francis Anthony (1550–1623), an English physician and alchemist, whom Maier would later befriend during his stay in London.³¹ Anthony, a Cambridge alumnus, was entangled in legal disputes with the College of Physicians due to his *aurum potabile*. Though heralded as a miraculous medicine – a view Maier shared from his initial exposure – it had reportedly caused the death of some patients.³² Maier assisted his friend by translating Anthony's *Apologie* (1616) into Latin.³³ Upon returning to Germany, Maier claimed his role in the project extended beyond translating to substantially co-authoring the work.³⁴ In an introduction he contributed to the front matter of Anthony's 1616 *Apologia*, Maier writes:

Legi vir clarissime tractatum tuum de Auro potabili apud vos in Anglia editum; argumentum sane et intentio bona; qui aliter aestimet, vix mihi inter bonos aestimandus. Flosculos tuos dulcissimos ex Chymiae verae hortis delibatos grato animo lustravi; verum cum illis binos areaneos venenosissimos infidere viderem, exque illo nectare venenum sibi haurire et texere futilia et inutilia retícula, vix me continere potui, quin illos túrgidos et horridos uno ictu ne dicam flatu dissiparem. At cum animadverterem eorum texturas et opuscula permultis admiranda existere, ideo nihil incommodi illis animalculis hactenus inferre volui, ne scilicet Crabrones cum arañéis conspirent. Mitto interim en spongiam Muriaticam, seu muria acri imbutam, qua plagas ab illis bestiis illatas aut virus infixum elvere, abstergere et sanare possis; aut si mavis, illorum non candidas lituras aut texturas delere et omnino suppressere. [...] Tui nominis obseruantissimus
HERMES MALAVICI.³⁵

Most distinguished sir, I have read your concise treatise about Potable Gold published in England. Indeed, the argument is sound and the intention noble; anyone who thinks otherwise is scarcely worthy of regard. I have gladly examined your sweet flowers, plucked from the gardens of true chymistry; but when I saw those two most venomous spiders lurking among them, and spilling their poison into their nectar and weaving futile and useless

²⁹ Leibenguth 2002, 39.

³⁰ Leibenguth 2002, 58.

³¹ Leibenguth 2002, 38.

³² Tilton 2003, 103.

³³ Anthony 1616b.

³⁴ Lenke, Roudet, and Tilton 2014; Lang 2021b.

³⁵ Anthony 1616a, 4r.

little nets, I could hardly contain myself so as not to scatter those swollen and horrid creatures with a single blow, not to say a fart. However, recognizing that their writings and treatises are admired by many, I restrained from harming these little pests, lest the hornets conspire with the spiders. Meanwhile, I send you a Muriatic sponge, soaked in sharp vinegar, with which you can wash away, cleanse, and heal the wounds inflicted by those little pests. Or, if you prefer, you can erase and altogether remove their dirty marks or webs. Observantly yours, HERMES MALAVICI.

This text is signed ‘Hermes Malavici’, a known and frequently used name anagram of Maier’s, and followed by the poem ‘Spongia Muriatica’, praising Anthony’s English Garden of the Hesperides, home to his potable gold but also infested by two spiders.³⁶ Maier initially sought patronage from Sir William Paddy (1554–1634), to whom he dedicated his *Arcana Arcanissima*.³⁷ Using Maier’s name anagram, *Spongia Muriatica* specifically targets Matthew Gwinne (1558?–1627), a friend of Paddy’s and co-commissioner of tobacco, as well as fellow chymist Thomas Rawlin. The poem allegorically depicts these critics as envious spiders threatening the Hesperides’ garden, with Hermes Malavici proposing a muriatic sponge to remove them delicately.³⁸ This metaphorical approach reflects Maier’s cautious stance, likely mindful of the influence of Sir Paddy, who had endorsed Gwinne’s refutation of Anthony’s *Assertio*³⁹ (*Aurum non Aurum*, 1611) and Rawlin’s writings on alchemical fraud (*Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis*, 1612).⁴⁰ Interestingly, Rawlin himself marketed a version of potable gold, opposing Anthony’s product in *Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis* not on the grounds of alchemical legitimacy but as a commercial competitor. This scenario illustrates the blurred lines in defining authentic and false alchemists, as Rawlin’s business model mirrored that of Maier and Anthony. Maier’s poem extensively criticizes Gwinne, with Rawlin receiving less attention. He employs mythological imagery, notably a basilisk, representing Anthony’s adversaries, against which Anthony’s praised potable gold is an antidote. Maier’s approach in this poem is direct in its criticism yet retains his anonymity, perhaps due to concerns about the repercussions from influential figures like Sir Paddy and the legal troubles faced by Anthony. These mutual accusations of fraud may have motivated Maier’s subsequent work, *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617), as he suggests in its introduction:

Cum aliquando in Anglia paucis ab hinc annis nonnihil bilis in eiusmodi fucos alchymicos, aut potius pseudo-chymicos, collegerim, non potui quiescere, quin eorum delineationem, calamo arrepto, instituerem, tum ut animo meo pro tempore indulgerem, tum ut bonis omnibus hanc quasi facem incenderem, [...]

A few years ago in England, when I had accumulated some bile against such alchemical or rather pseudo-chymical impostors, I could not rest without taking up the pen and sketching their description. I did this both to appease my own mind at the time and to ignite this torch for the benefit of all good people, [...].⁴¹

In *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum*, Michael Maier appears to directly reference Thomas Rawlin’s 1612 work *Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis*, even adopting the term ‘pseudo-chymists’ for his title,

³⁶ A partial English translation of the poem can be found in: Tilton 2003, 104.

³⁷ Maier 1614.

³⁸ Tilton 2003, 106.

³⁹ Anthony 1610.

⁴⁰ Gwinne 1611; Rawlin 1612.

⁴¹ Maier 1617b, A2v.

suggesting a deliberate response to Rawlin's critique. Maier's 1619 *Verum Inventum* was a rejoinder to Matthew Gwinne's anti-German sentiments, extolling German contributions to various fields, including theology, medicine, chemistry, and the printing press; it even compares Germany to ancient Egypt as a fertile ground for arts and inventions.⁴² Here, Maier acknowledges Paracelsus as a vital mediator of hermetic science, portraying him as a misunderstood figure emblematic of Germany's cultural legacy.⁴³

7 *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616) and mental constipation

Maier's commitment to *aurum potabile* is further evident in *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616). This short work, Maier's first Frankfurt publication after returning from England, is a medico-alchemical treatise focusing on the medicinal virtues of gold and sometimes called his "Monograph on Gold."⁴⁴ Dedicated to Moritz of Hessen-Kassel, it likely served as an application to his later patron.⁴⁵ The title's wordplay alludes to the concept of squaring the (alchemical) circle, relating to gold's perfection.⁴⁶ The treatise delves into the correspondence between gold, the sun, and the heart, exploring the idea that gold, embodying the perfect circle, also contains a balance of the four elemental qualities.⁴⁷

Maier actively sought the support of a prince interested in alchemy through *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*. In it, he refers to a contentious encounter with a rival alchemist in Cologne, whose views on starting materials and *medicina aurea* (golden medicine) clashed with Maier's. This disagreement motivated the publication of *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*.⁴⁸ There are reasons to believe that the invective might target the London physician and censor Gwinne, known for opposing Francis Anthony's *aurum potabile*. However, Leibenguth proposed that Johann Grasse, Maier's familiar adversary, could be the subject.⁴⁹ In his excellent update on Maier's biography, Oliver Humberg was able to demonstrate that the poem is directed at the Cologne professor of medicine Petrus Holtzemius (1570–1651).⁵⁰ The latter had written about Maier in his *Essentia bellebori extracta* and thereby, almost thwarted the publication of Maier's *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*, by accusing the latter of fraud. Consequently, when Maier successfully published his treatise, he triumphantly appended an anacreontic poem (*Cantilena Anacreontica*) to the end of *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*. This poem not only summarizes the work but is also laden with bitter polemic, reflecting Maier's personal grievances. This insult might shed light on why Maier later portrayed himself as the antithesis of a fraudulent alchemist in *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617). The fact that Holtzemius acknowledged

⁴² Leibenguth 2002, 55; Tilton 2003, 37; Kühlmann 2010, 621; 2015, 261.

⁴³ Leibenguth 2002, 73.

⁴⁴ Leibenguth 2002, 56; Kühlmann 2010, 621; Lang 2021a, 194–97.

⁴⁵ Moran 1991, 106.

⁴⁶ Oosterhoff 2020.

⁴⁷ Maier 1616a, 50; Tilton 2003, 183; Kühlmann 2015, 261.

⁴⁸ *Epistola dedicatoria*, Maier 1616a, 4–5; Leibenguth 2002, 57.

⁴⁹ Leibenguth 2002, 427.

⁵⁰ Oliver Humberg, 400 Jahre nach Michael Maier – eine aktualisierte Biographie, in: Michael Maier und die Formen (al)chemischen Wissens um 1600, Volkhard Wels & Simon Brandl (eds.), to appear with Harrassowitz.

being the target of Maier's insult in the second edition of *Essentia hellebori extracta* supports this interpretation.⁵¹ While Maier directly addresses his conflict with Holtzemius in the summary of his work in the *Cantilena Anacreontica*, he already alludes to this dispute in the dedicatory letter (*Epistola dedicatoria*) of *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*, referring to Holtzemius's practice as *elleborismus*.⁵² Maier's securing of a position with Moritz of Hessen-Kassel, to whom the book is dedicated, in 1618 suggests it was well-calculated to defend his medico-chymical strategy by finally committing his theory to writing, as he says he had been meaning to do for a while.

The *Cantilena Anacreontea*, constituting the twelfth chapter of the *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*, summarizes Maier's arguments against skeptics of gold's medicinal value in alchemy. This poem serves as an invective, countering the critics of *alchemia medica*, especially those doubting the solubility or digestibility of gold. Drawing inspiration from Horace's *Epodes*, Maier employs subtle ambiguities and double meanings. His tactic of using an extra dose of hellebore against Holtzemius echoes the ancient *ius talionis* – fighting back with the opponent's own methods. The iambic poem's meter, a catalectic iambic tetrameter, aligns with the traditional use of iambi for satirical verses.⁵³

⁵¹ Interim dum haec relego, offertur mihi scriptum alicujus Medici, immodicae profecto in me libertatis, Paracelsicae imposturae maximi buccinatoris, fraternitatis roseae crucis, magicae, dico coniurationis, insignis causidici, qui vere ingenium suum ad id dicendi, et scribendi genus idcirco accomodasse videtur, ut aurum suum putatium, quod sub titulo circuli physici quadrati, quasi in auro quadratura siue aequalitas quatuor qualitatum existat, credulo populo dolose obtrudere, et sua sophistica, multiformique scriptione exornare possit [...]. Petrus Holtzemius, *Essentia hellebori rediviva, secundo extracta sive rectificata et aucta*. Köln 1623, 31–33. – Translation: While I am re-reading these things in the meantime (i.e. preparing the second edition of his book), a document is presented to me from a certain doctor, who is truly offensive (intemperately outspoken) towards me, the greatest trumpeter of the Paracelsian imposture[#] and an excellent advocate of the Rosy Cross fraternity – a magical conspiracy, I say –, who appears to have accommodated his natural talent for speaking and writing so that he can cunningly impose his alleged gold, which exists under the designation “natural square circle”, as if the quadrature or balance of the four qualities existed in gold, on the gullible people and embellish it with his sophistry and multifarious writings [...].

⁵² *Epistola dedicatoria*, Maier 1616a, 4–5. Quod scriptum, cum jam pridem de eo concipiendi cogitârim, nunc, dum Coloniae paucis ab hinc diebus subsisterem, mihi extorsit, ferè Ephemerum, cujusdam nimis iniqui et precocis authoris Elleborismus, omnibus Chymicis et ex auro, aliisve metallicis (ut abusus medicinae rectè taxatos non taxem) medicamenta ad hominum salutem spectantia, praeparantibus, instar, fortissimae purgationis propinatus. Cum verò nonnulli inter Chymiae, nostrique amantes hoc inprimis publicari cuperent, ne scilicet Veritas in herba, quod dicitur, supprimatur, at pro cujuslibet virili à calumniis adversantium liberetur, hujus gratiâ hanc arenam descendere non sum veritus, cujus cum Celsitudo Vestra patrociniū nunquam non suscipiat, non est quod dubitem, quin clementissimam eidem jam manum praebitura sit, cui quantulumcunque tractatum dico et obfero, eamque Divinae protectioni diutissimè commendo. Francurto ad Moenum: Anno 1616. Mense Augusto. – Translation: This writing, which I had long considered conceiving, was wrung from me now, while I stayed in Cologne a few days ago, nearly an Ephemerum, by the Elleborismus of a certain unjust and premature author, offered to all chemists and those preparing medicines for the health of mankind from gold or other metals as a very strong purgation (so as not to unjustly criticize the rightful condemnation of medicine's abuses). Some among our fellow lovers of Chymistry desired its publication, lest truth, as it is said, be suppressed while still in the bud, but be delivered from the calumnies of its adversaries. For the sake of truth, I did not hesitate to engage in this task, descend into this arena, whose patronage Your Highness always accepts, so there is no reason for me to doubt that you will now extend the most gracious hand to it, to which I dedicate and offer this small treatise. In doing so, I commend Your Highness to Divine protection. Frankfurt on the Main: Year 1616. Month of August. See also Leibenguth 2002, 57.

⁵³ Leibenguth 2002, 427.

Maier begins with a reference to Anticyra, a city famed for its hellebore, used historically as a cure for madness. He employs puns and contrasts to inject irony and humor, suggesting that those doubting gold's medicinal efficacy should undergo purgation with hellebore in Anticyra, to cleanse the mind and sharpen the senses. Maier presents gold not as food but as a medicine with holistic healing properties, akin to laxatives purifying the blood. He details the various remedies from Anticyra, including wolf's milk, honey vinegar, and hellebore. The plant-based drugs discussed by Maier can have powerful effects. Hellebore, especially, can be lethal in large doses. In the early modern era, laxatives like *Euphorbia*, *scammonium*, and *elleborus* were believed to expel harmful fluids from the blood.⁵⁴ Maier lists only herbal drugs (*simplicia*), aligning with his critic's preference, implying that Holtzemius would not find relief from these, but persist in his misguided beliefs. The exaggerated recommendation of a pound of the hellebore concoction for his adversary is hyperbolic, underscoring the perceived severity of his mental constipation.⁵⁵

Hinc stultior Coraebo, Midae sodalis audis,
 Nomen Petrae molaris habens vel omen hinni.
 Euphorbii calentis, vel scammoni triuncem
 Huic oxymellis acris libram vel ELLEBORati
 Offerte, nec sit ullus post exhibenda somnus:
 Purgatius cerebrum quo fiat Elleborato
 Subtiliorque sensus, sagaciorque mentis
 Discursus à tenebris et nube liberatus.
 Non sufficit saburram ter centies per alvum
 Jecisse, duplicatas sed per vices juvabit,
 Ut omne virus efflet per os calumniosum
 Emittat et recessus per Corporis profundos.

Hence, you are called more foolish than Coraebus, companion of Midas, you carry the name 'millstone' or the fate of a hinny (offspring of a male horse and a female donkey). Offer him hot *euphorbium* (spurge) or three ounces of scammony juice, a pound of sharp oxymel (honey vinegar), or HELLEBORE, he shall not find sleep afterward. Through the use of hellebore, the brain shall be purified and the senses made more subtle, and the reasoning of the mind becomes more acute, freed from darkness and clouds. It is not enough for him to have expelled the bile three hundred times through the bowels, but it will be helpful to do so twice as many times for a change, so that he exhale every poison through his deceitful mouth and expels them through the inner recesses of his body.⁵⁶

⁵⁴ They were already mentioned by Maier in Maier 1609 Bl. D^v; Leibenguth 2002, 434, footnote 32.

⁵⁵ Leibenguth 2002, 434, footnote 32.

⁵⁶ Maier 1616a, 75–79, the passage cited is on page 78. The Latin text and a German translation with brief commentary are provided in Leibenguth 2002, 427–37, passage quoted 432–435, verses 93–102; commentary: footnote 32, 433.

In his *Cantilena Anacreontica*, Maier reasserts the medical benefits of gold and denounces those who reject its therapeutic properties. The lengthy satirical poem culminates in a recommendation of a lethal dose of hellebore to cleanse his opponent's madness. This *elleborismus* treatment, Holtzemius's medical specialty, is used by Maier in a *simile cum simili* approach, turning Holtzemius's own method against him. The suggested half-pound of hellebore is a clear exaggeration, underscoring the absurdity of his adversary's erroneous beliefs.

8 *Jocus Severus* (1617): Rosicrucianism attacked by cantankerous birds

In 1617, Maier dedicated his *Iocus Severus* to the Rosicrucians. This prosimetric debate poem stages the Owl – who personifies *chemia*, the “art of arts” and “science of sciences” –, on trial before a court of birds.⁵⁷ The poem is an apology of *chymia*, in the guise of a bird council, in which the Owl is ultimately elected queen of the birds for her wisdom. Maier categorizes Chymia's critics into three groups: the ignorant (Jay, Magpie, Raven, Goose, Swallow), the greedy (Cuckoo, Jackdaw, Woodpecker, Heron), and those who vociferously defame chymistry. Similar to Maier's *Lusus Serius*, where Mercury is crowned king of animals, plants, and minerals beneficial to humanity, the animal dispute poem *Iocus Severus* employs the *ioca seria* form, a popular communication strategy for precarious knowledge.⁵⁸ According to Maier's preface, the Owl not only represents true chymists but specifically the Brethren of the Rosy Cross, dedicated to the art of *chemia* and the production of the Universal Medicine. Similar strategies of dedicating works to the Rosicrucians to signal to new buyers can be found in Arthur Dee's works for instance.⁵⁹ The absence of direct references to the Rosicrucian Brotherhood in the main text of *Iocus Severus* indicates that the preface was a later addition.⁶⁰

9 *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) and Defending Lady Chymia

The emerging persona of the fraudulent alchemist as a social type in the public imagination was recognized as a threat by alchemical authors, leading chymists like Maier to reframe themselves as allies against fraud rather than its perpetrators, distinguishing their authentic alchemical skills from deceptive manipulations.⁶¹ *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* stands as a warning against the

⁵⁷ Leibenguth 2002, 56, 85; Kühlmann 2015, 262; Lang 2021a, 236–37.

⁵⁸ Maier 1616b; cf. Obermaier 2010, 311–14. Mulsow 2012, 18.

⁵⁹ cf. Piorko 2019; 2020, 48–68.

⁶⁰ Tilton 2003, 132–33.

⁶¹ However, the apologetic aspect was part of the alchemical tradition since the late thirteenth century, as evidenced by works such as Newman 1989, Crisciani & Pereira 1996, Kahn 2007, and many more. Michael Maier's work appears towards the culmination of this lineage of apologetic literature, preceding the final contributions to the genre, such as those in Roth-Scholtz's *Deutsches Theatrum Chemicum* (three volumes, 1728–1732).

practices of fraudulent alchemical practitioners.⁶² Yet, this work doubles as a performative act within the context of entrepreneurial alchemy, despite ostensibly critiquing it.⁶³ On the surface, the *Examen* serves as a critique of false alchemists but acts as an apology for ‘true chymistry’ at the same time. Through this dual-purpose framing, Maier strategically crafts his persona as a credible expert within the alchemical marketplace, distancing himself from those he accuses of fraud and thereby establishing the archetype of the ideal chymist. This figure is portrayed as a master of hermeneutics, embodying scholarly values along with moral and ethical ones. Additionally, the *Examen* emphasizes the necessity of a comprehensive education for a ‘true researcher of chymistry’ (*chymiae verae indagator*).⁶⁴ This education extends beyond practical metallurgy and alchemical theory to include the liberal arts, natural philosophy, and other sciences.⁶⁵ Proficiency in Latin is crucial for accessing the substantial literature of the alchemical tradition.⁶⁶

The title of Maier's text, *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-chymicorum detectorum et in gratiam veritatis amantium succincte refutatorum*, which can be translated as “The Swarm of Pseudo-Chymical Drones,” is a play on ambiguous words: The term *Examen* refers both to “examination” or “investigation,” and “swarm” (of insects), while *fucus*, denotes “false appearance, deception” as well as “drone bee.” This allows for an alternative interpretation of the title as “The Swarm of [...] Pseudo-Chemical Drones” rather than the straightforward “Examination of the Exposed Pseudo-Chemical Fraudsters, Briefly Refuted for the Lovers of Truth.”⁶⁷ Maier explains this intentional ambiguity in his *Epistola dedicatoria*.⁶⁸ This wordplay between bees and drones evokes a longstanding literary motif, likening the poet to a bee and his poetry to honey, which sweetens the bitterness of medicine (Lucr., *de rerum natura* 1,934–950) – a trope Maier, as a poet laureate, would have certainly been aware of.⁶⁹ This adds another dimension to the *fucus* pun: Not only does Maier characterize the ideal chymist, busy as a bee, as the opposite of a lazy drone, but he also indirectly describes the chymist, if not as a poet, then at least as a master of hermeneutics, and equates alchemy with poetry or high courtly culture. While Maier does not explicitly mention this dimension, it must have stood out to anybody with a Humanistic background in Classics.

This literary strategy enables Maier to elaborate on the archetype of the ideal chymist, setting it against the backdrop of fraudulent practitioners. Through the subtext and framing of the main text, Maier

⁶² Leibenguth 2002, 56; Kühlmann 2010, 621; Lang 2021a, 229–35.

⁶³ cf. Nummedal 2007, 170.

⁶⁴ Figala and Neumann 1990, 49. Leibenguth 2002, 58. Maier insists on distinguishing his discipline as *chymia* or *chemia*, distancing it from *alchemia* or *alcumia*, terms that had acquired negative connotations. In his framework, genuine practitioners are termed *chymici*, while imposters and charlatans are labeled *pseudo-chymici* or alchemists. See Rampling 2014, 708–10.

⁶⁵ Maier 1617b, 13–19; Figala and Neumann 1990, 49.

⁶⁶ Nummedal 2007, 36–38.

⁶⁷ Beck 1991, 21.

⁶⁸ Beck 1991, 26–27.

⁶⁹ On the trope of bee and honey, see Berrens 2015.

engages in sophisticated self-fashioning: he not only distances himself from deceitful alchemists but also asserts himself as a trustworthy authority.

The title engraving depicts a modestly dressed chymist before an oven, flanked by three elegantly dressed figures, presumably noble patrons, who offer him laboratory instruments and a purse of money.⁷⁰ Nummedal interprets this as an implicit critique of wealthy patrons who inadvertently encourage fraud by offering substantial financial incentives; thus, placing the responsibility for hiring fraudsters upon the patrons themselves, while good chymists strive to differentiate their authentic practice from that of their deceptive counterparts.⁷¹ The epigram accompanying the engraving extols the virtues of hardworking bees that must protect themselves from the lazy but aggressive drones. Through this allegory, Maier characterizes the fraudsters as alchemical dandies preoccupied with appearances not only in their show experiments, but also in their looks, demeanor, and expensive laboratory equipment.

Maier's text distinguishes three types of alchemical practitioners: the true, the unsuccessful, and the fraudulent chymists.⁷² In the introduction of his tract,⁷³ Maier characterizes the false alchemist by their lack of education,⁷⁴ propensity for making empty promises,⁷⁵ emphasis on appearances,⁷⁶ and, most importantly, engagement in fraudulent manipulation, which accounts for the majority of the book's content. Maier's text relies heavily on Heinrich Khunrath regarding this main characteristic of fraudulent manipulation: The fourth chapter of the *Examen* is a translation of Khunrath's *Trewhertzige Warnungs-Vermahnung eines getrewen Liebhabers der Wahrheit* (1597), which Maier replicates nearly verbatim, save for two brief exceptions.⁷⁷

Although the *Examen* may appear at first glance to be a rejection of performative entrepreneurial alchemy, it embodies a "performance [...] of expertise in the marketplace" in its own right.⁷⁸ Accusations of alchemical fraud emerged together with the genre of transmutation histories, both

⁷⁰ Beck 1991, 23–26.

⁷¹ Nummedal 2007, 163–64.

⁷² Nummedal references this tripartite distinction of alchemist personae derived Sebastian Brant's *Narrenschiff* – the deliberately deceptive alchemist or fraud, the incompetent fool or sophist, and the genuine alchemist who achieves success honestly (Nummedal 2007, chapter 2 *The Alchemist's Personae*, 40–72, especially 55–57). This classification is mirrored in Maier's publications: Beck asserts that the *Examen* (Maier 1617b) should be considered in connection with two other works by Maier, the *Symbola* (Maier 1617d) and the *Viatorium* (Maier 1618b), which collectively examine different facets of chymical practitioners ("artifices") within Maier's taxonomy. In the *Examen*, Maier (like Brant) distinguishes between three types of chymists: the true and successful chymists (whom the *Symbola* praise), the well-meaning and honest but unsuccessful chymists (whom he aspires to guide out of the labyrinth of chemistry with the *Viatorium*), and the false alchemists and frauds (whom he addresses in the *Examen*). As the author persona, Maier assumes different roles in each of the texts: that of historian (*Symbola*), teacher and leader for the confused (*Viatorium*), or apologist and accuser (*Examen*).

⁷³ Maier 1617b, 12–13.

⁷⁴ Beck 1991, 31–39.

⁷⁵ Beck 1991, 39–43.

⁷⁶ Beck 1991, 43–45.

⁷⁷ Beck 1991, 45–57, especially 46. Khunrath 1597. This suggests the *Examen* might be counted amongst Maier's translations along with *Tripus Aureus* (Maier 1618a) and Francis Anthony's *Apologia* (1616a).

⁷⁸ Nummedal 2007, 170.

functioning as apologies for alchemy: By attributing failures to the malicious intentions of individuals rather than the discipline itself, proponents and practitioners could continue to advocate for alchemy as a viable solution for economic issues, sidestepping public failures as arguments against alchemy's practical and intellectual validity.⁷⁹ Maier's *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* thus parallels the genre of successful transmutation legends, serving as an apologetic narrative for chymistry amidst accusations of alchemical fraud,⁸⁰ which "serve to authenticate the existence of *Betrüger*", just as successful transmutation stories emphasize the credibility and reality of the possibility of transmutation: "Stories of true and false alchemy, in other words, emerged in tandem."⁸¹ Still, fraudulent practices described by Maier and others like him may have been as much fabrications of the alchemical apologetic imagination as the transmutation stories flourishing at the time.⁸² Authors like Maier had vested interests in promoting tales of fraud to bolster their own status as alchemical experts. Those very narratives intended to uphold alchemy's authority, ironically, were later used to critique the discipline during the Enlightenment because they highlighted its problematic side and thus, contributed to its declining public reputation.⁸³ Tara Nummedal argues that such texts played a significant role in the performative aspect of entrepreneurial alchemy, fueling the market just like show experiments.⁸⁴ The controversy surrounding alchemy, intensified by fraud trials, not only tarnished its chymistry's public image but also intensified market competition. Despite Maier and others denouncing 'false alchemists' for their focus on appearance and public perception, their publications were motivated by similar desires to secure patronage "because they, too, recognized that authority in alchemical matters was determined, in part, through performances of expertise in the marketplace."⁸⁵

10 Conclusion: The best defense is a good offense?

This article has examined iatrochymist Michael Maier's (1569–1622) use of invectives and apologetic strategies, which, as this study has demonstrated, all revolve around accusations of alchemical fraud.

⁷⁹ Nummedal 2007, 175.

⁸⁰ See for example: Güldenfalk 1784.

⁸¹ Nummedal 2007, 170. Transmutation legends, often featuring mysterious adepts, emerged between the 16th and 17th centuries and aimed to convince skeptics of alchemy's legitimacy by means other than scholarly argument. These stories often involve anonymous or pseudonymous characters hardly traceable in the historical record, such as Nicolas Flamel. Yet, they offer insight into the mythology surrounding alchemical transmutation and the archetype of the successful alchemist, counterbalancing the image of the fraudulent alchemist. Maier draws on the tropes of transmutation legends in the narrative framing for his autobiographical account in *Coelidonia*. On transmutation legends see Strein 1999, Prinke 2010 and Kahn 2014. Prinke 2010 specifically examines Michael Sendivogius, a genuinely successful alchemist who diverges from typical narratives of mysterious, ephemeral figures, demonstrating what truly constituted success in alchemical pursuits.

⁸² Nummedal 2007, 172.

⁸³ Principe 2013, 178–81. Zuber 2021.

⁸⁴ Nummedal 2007, 159–75.

⁸⁵ Nummedal 2007, 170.

Maier's strategies to anticipate criticism and avoid being attacked by others are a fascinating testimony to the tense atmosphere in the scientific communities he moved in. We encounter *saeva scientia* not only in Maier's flight from Padua following a violent dispute but also through the insults in his publications, even though most of them are indirect. His most aggressive stances emerge when his livelihood and entrepreneurial ambitions are threatened, rather than in cases of scholarly dissent. Maier's invectives helped him navigate the definition of a reputable practitioner and thus, protect his livelihood as an entrepreneurial alchemist. His insults are themselves performances of expertise, staging fraud and legitimate practice in the competitive alchemical marketplace. Michael Maier's invectives were multifaceted and motivated by various circumstances. His reluctance to engage in the Paracelsianism debate contrasts with his open support for the Rosicrucian movement. Personal experiences played a significant role in shaping his responses and writings. The Grasse incident serves as a handy narrative frame for Maier as a retardation tactic in his ascent to alchemical success. Holtzemius' disparaging comments nearly derailed the publication of one of his works. This challenge was personal, yet the response extended beyond Maier's individual interests as the defense of a medical and entrepreneurial strategy.

Maier's scholarly reputation is well-established, but this article has revealed a pronounced entrepreneurial inclination, not immediately apparent in his celebrated Humanistic mythoalchemical works. It suggests Maier embodied a blend of entrepreneur and scholar, challenging the divide between scholar-chemists and entrepreneur-fraudsters as a false dichotomy. Far from being merely a theoretician or a master of mythoalchemy, Maier actively engaged in alchemical practice. Unsurprisingly, his use of invective and apologetic strategies was aimed at defending his livelihood as an entrepreneurial alchemist. This analysis illustrates that narratives of fraud did not solely target the more workday practitioners of chymistry but also blurred the lines between scholarly and entrepreneurial identities, contrary to what historical figures like Maier might have preferred their audience to believe. In disputes about alchemical fraud in Maier's era, the contention was not simply between scholars and more workday entrepreneurial practitioners, but also amongst scholar-entrepreneurs. Contrary to the notion that those accused of fraud were uneducated or illiterate, each individual implicated in Maier's narratives was, more or less, scholarly and erudite. They were well-versed in Latin and actively contributed to the alchemical discourse through their publications.⁸⁶ This underscores that scholarly debate and entrepreneurial ambition intersected in chymical practice, leading to conflicts not over the legitimacy of alchemy itself but over the authority of its proponents.

This study underscores that the stock tale of alchemical fraud, which Maier may well have orchestrated within his texts, serves more as a narrative strategy than a historical account of actual fraud perpetrated,

⁸⁶ Francis Anthony, probably the least erudite among those implicated in fraud accusations amongst Maier's contemporaries, was critiqued for his Latin, which, while adequate, lacked the Humanistic flair of Maier's. Thus, Anthony's Latin proficiency was questioned, which undermined his credibility as a genuine chymist. Maier assisted Anthony in writing better Latin but Maier himself echoed this sentiment in *Examen*, suggesting that proficiency in Latin and hermeneutics was essential for respectable practitioners. This stance implied that Anthony's weaker Latin skills could detract from his standing as a skilled alchemist, inadvertently aligning him with alchemical fraudsters.

echoing Tara Nummedal's caution against taking such narratives at face value.⁸⁷ Authors like Maier had vested interests in promoting tales of fraud to bolster their status as alchemical experts by undermining the credibility of other entrepreneurial alchemists in the competition for patronage. The ambiguity in defining alchemical fraud critically influenced the discourse of alchemists like Maier, allowing them to leverage fraud accusations as a tactic to outcompete rivals for patronage. In the absence of formal contracts or legal frameworks, like those characterizing Maier's dealings with Grasse, the definition of fraud becomes subjective and open to debate, reflecting a matter of perspective rather than an offense with clearly spelled-out, objective criteria.

These recurrent allegations reveal a discourse aimed at exonerating alchemy from failure, aligning with Tara Nummedal's conclusions; but mutual accusations of fraud, even among those offering similar products, gradually damaged alchemy's broader reputation, as Mike Zuber has demonstrated.⁸⁸ Accusations of fraud were strategically used as apologetic devices in early modern alchemy. Branding Grasse as a fraud not only validated Maier's transition to legitimate practice but primarily functioned as a narrative strategy. Anthony's conflict with Rawlin over potable gold illustrates the strategic use of such invectives in safeguarding entrepreneurial interests without undermining the overall credibility of chymical remedies. Rawlin aimed to eliminate competition, suggesting that negative outcomes under Anthony's care stemmed from his unreliability, not the inefficacy of potable gold itself, thus, implying that, in competent hands, potable gold could indeed fulfill its promises.

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⁸⁷ Nummedal 2007, 172.

⁸⁸ Nummedal 2007; Zuber 2021.

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Minus 50 Fugis Musicalibus Trium Vocum, Quarum Duae Ad Unum Simplicem Melodiam Distichis Canendis Peraptam, Correspondeant, Non Absque, Singulari Jucunditate Videnda, Legenda, Meditanda, Intelligenda, Dijudicanda, Canenda Et Audienda (Oppenheim: de Bry, 1617a).

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